

A SHORT HAPPY POEM FOR MARIANNE MOORE

She did not chide me for my poetry,
But told me I was ignorant and needed help
That first summer in New York: while she explained
The niceties to me at Ebbets Field
The Bums lost and so a disaster had to be buried
In victory upon another hot bright day
When Marianne's hat, uniquely, was worn away.

While I sipped Dubonnet in Cumberland Street,
Instead of verse we spoke of carpentry
And dime-store tools. We exchanged peculiar information,
Drawings of flowers and, surprisingly, gossip.
Her invitation of the poet I was going to see
On the marble steps at Hartford is more alive
In memory than the old man ever was himself.

I wanted to give her a Guardia Civil hat,
A gleaming black triangle with golden braid
In fungoid encrustation, but I was too late.
I look at the white columbine she drew
And sent me from the garden of Bryn Mawr:
I imagine her poised in her ambiguous heaven,
A tea-cup balanced and wearing, inevitably, a tricorn halo.

Ruthven Todd